word used by the ancient Persians to also refer to the subcontinent and all its inhabitants (pronouncing ‘s’ as ‘h’), a non-religious, ethno-geographic descriptor. What did these travellers think of the Indians they met and what challenges of cross-cultural understanding did they face? Alongside, I would present my own experience of these sites and encounters as a traveller. In short, I hoped to bring alive these sites, past and present, in rich and evocative detail, combining the big picture with telling minutiae and quirky anecdotes. In doing so, I hoped to illuminate the most consequential trends, transformations and fault lines of Indian civilization.

I was inspired to write such a book, a book of connecting the dots, of relating ideas and emotions of our ancestors with our own. With my task cut out, I began gathering the sources and making travel plans to revisit the six sites. Three years later, I had this book.

On Approaching the Past

How should one tell the story of a lost world? By being truthful, one might say, by sticking to the facts. But what does that really mean? Facts are one thing, their interpretation another. Facts don’t explain how they became facts, or why we care about some facts more than the other facts—only stories do that.

Inseparable from every story is the storyteller’s sensibility, shaped by her politics, identity and culture. This is nothing new; it has always been true of all stories, including my stories in this book. There is no impartial or omniscient chronicler of events, no ‘scientific’ history. The storyteller’s subjectivity and bias are woven into the very selection of what she considers to be salient facts and the weight she assigns them in her narrative.

Strictly speaking, ‘all stories are fictions’, wrote historian Hayden White. In the words of a critic, White held ‘that while historical facts are scientifically verifiable, stories are not. Stories are made, not found in the historical data; historical meaning is imposed on historical facts by means of the choice of plot-type, and this choice is inevitably ethical and political at bottom’.[1]